

ULTRA-PORTABLES

Ultra-portable laptops are for frequent fliers who need an extremely light and small device. They are made keeping size in mind, and hence do not perform as well as their bigger siblings—the thin and light laptops. They are small and light enough for you to lug them around the whole day without tiring yourself. Ultra-portables usually have LCD screens measuring not more than 12 inches; the ones with a 10-inch screen are termed sub-notebooks.

Their small size results in poor ergonomics and the keys might end up giving you sore fingers. These small machines are

PnP Ultra-portable laptop

Processor weak

The PnP ultra-portable laptop was based on the VIA Antuar platform. The compact dimensions of this notebook compelled us to put it in the ultra-portable category. It weighs just 1.4 Kgs and measures a mere 27 x 21 x 25 inches. It comes with a 1 GHz VIA Nehemiah CPU, 256 MB of RAM, a 40 GB hard drive and an S3 graphics core. No legacy ports are available, but you get two USB ports and a Firewire port for data transfer.



It has a reasonably large keyboard that is well spaced out for comfortable typing. The keys are extremely responsive. The touchpad is sensitive and track true, while the accuracy is spot on. The ports are ideally placed for easy and unhindered usage.

The off-black finish and subtle use of silver at the base of the lid lend it a stern character. The same theme continues on its inside and makes it stand out from the rest of the crowd.

VIA processors are never known to be powerhouses, and the same is reflected in the FPU scores, which is the weakest on all VIA processor. This weakness was also reflected in all the graphics benchmarks such as *Quake III* and 3D Mark 2001 SE. The hard disk holds up to the demand quite well. The battery life is, as usual, near the 3-hour mark.

Given its configuration, it's priced expensively at Rs 69,999. Its only USP is its extremely low profile design that makes it light and compact. It gets most of your light work done in a jiffy, but crawls along when faced with any processor-intensive tasks. We recommend it to those on the lookout for an extremely light and ultra-portable laptop at an affordable price.

PnP Ultra-portable laptop		A-
Performance	    	
Features	    	
Usability	    	
Value for money	    	

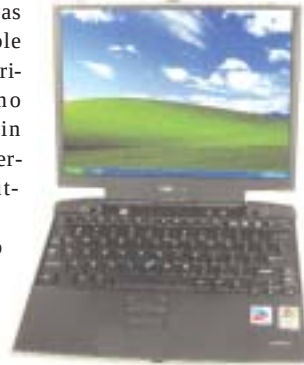
Price: Rs 69,999
+ Extremely light and portable
- Expensive for its configuration

mainly used to work with Word processors, make Powerpoint presentations and check e-mail while on the move. Previously, many of these laptops used Intel's PIII range of processors. However, the new breed has adopted the latest Centrino mobile technology that offers inbuilt wireless connectivity, longer battery life and sleeker designs, without compromising on performance. The batteries on the new Centrino models last for at least 3 hours; pre-defined power schemes such as Presentation, Movie, etc, extend that period to 4 hours.

Toshiba Portégé M100

Raise a toast

The Toshiba Portégé M100 was the only true ultra-portable that made it to this comparison. Based on the latest Centrino technology, it packs a lot of punch in its small body. The M100 looks terrific in its champagne-coloured outfit.



Black side panels line the crisp 12-inch TFT LCD. The jet-black keyboard and the blue track point contrast well with its gold colour. The top lid is hinged to the centre of the base, while the chubby speakers protrude out at its extremities.

The keys are fairly spaced out, and you don't fumble while typing. Our only gripe was the positioning of the Windows key with the function keys at the top of the keyboard. A pointing stick along with four buttons fills in for the touchpad. The placement of these buttons with respect to the pointing stick is perfect, and does not require you to stretch your fingers. Weighing 1.9 Kgs and measures 26.5 x 24.5 x 35 inches, which is quite compact. Despite being that small, it manages to offer a combo-drive.

In the overall system benchmark that used Business Winstone, the M100 delivered an astounding 25 units—the best score you can get on an ultra-portable. This can be attributed to the Pentium M 1.2 GHz CPU that uses the Centrino platform. Similar results were seen across the board, indicating the presence of high-performance hardware. The 40 GB hard drive delivered a commendable performance. The graphics sub-system is powerful enough to get along with most of the old 3D games. The batteries lasted for about 3 hours. Use a power scheme and you gain an extra hour.

For an ultra-portable, Rs 1,79,999 is expensive, but it's the best compact travel companion that money can buy.

Toshiba Portégé M100	
Performance	    
Features	    
Usability	    
Value for money	    

Price: Rs 1,79,999
+ Great looks and good performance
- Slightly cramped keyboard